

# Artificial Intelligence & Machine Learning

A Comprehensive Knowledge Guide

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Foundations · Algorithms · Deep Learning · NLP · Computer Vision  
Training & Evaluation · MLOps · Ethics · Applications · Glossary

Prepared by Claude (Anthropic) — an educational reference document.

# Table of Contents

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1. Introduction to AI and Machine Learning
2. Types of Machine Learning
3. The Machine Learning Workflow
4. Core Algorithms and Models
5. Neural Networks and Deep Learning
6. Deep Learning Architectures
7. Natural Language Processing & Large Language Models
8. Computer Vision
9. Training Concepts & Optimization
10. Model Evaluation Metrics
11. Overfitting, Regularization & Generalization
12. Reinforcement Learning
13. MLOps & Deployment
14. Ethics, Safety & Responsible AI
15. Real-World Applications
16. Glossary of Key Terms

# 1. Introduction to AI and Machine Learning

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**Artificial Intelligence (AI)** is the broad field of computer science concerned with building systems that perform tasks normally requiring human intelligence — reasoning, perception, language understanding, planning, and decision-making. **Machine Learning (ML)** is a subfield of AI in which systems learn patterns from data rather than following explicitly hand-coded rules. **Deep Learning (DL)** is a further subfield of ML that uses multi-layered artificial neural networks to learn hierarchical representations of data.

## The AI / ML / DL Relationship

- **AI** — the overarching goal: machines that exhibit intelligent behavior.
- **ML** — a set of techniques that let machines improve at a task through experience (data), without explicit programming for every scenario.
- **DL** — an ML approach based on artificial neural networks with many layers, especially effective on unstructured data such as images, audio, and text.

## A Brief History

- **1950s** — Alan Turing proposes the Turing Test; the term "Artificial Intelligence" is coined at the 1956 Dartmouth Workshop.
- **1960s–70s** — Early symbolic/rule-based AI and expert systems; the first "AI winter" follows unmet expectations.
- **1980s–90s** — Revival via backpropagation for neural networks, statistical ML, and decision trees.
- **2006–2012** — Deep learning re-emerges; GPUs enable training larger networks.
- **2012** — AlexNet dramatically wins the ImageNet competition, sparking the modern deep learning boom.
- **2014–2017** — Generative Adversarial Networks (GANs), sequence-to-sequence models, and the Transformer architecture (2017) are introduced.
- **2018–2022** — Large pretrained language models (BERT, GPT series) transform NLP.
- **2022–present** — Generative AI (ChatGPT, diffusion image models, multimodal models) reaches mainstream adoption; rapid growth in AI agents, reasoning models, and enterprise deployment.

## 2. Types of Machine Learning

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### 2.1 Supervised Learning

The model learns a mapping from labeled input-output pairs. Given enough examples of inputs (features) and correct outputs (labels), the model learns to predict labels for new, unseen inputs.

- **Classification** — predicting a discrete category (e.g., spam vs. not spam).
- **Regression** — predicting a continuous value (e.g., house price).
- Common algorithms: linear/logistic regression, decision trees, random forests, support vector machines, gradient boosting, neural networks.

### 2.2 Unsupervised Learning

The model finds structure in data without labeled outputs.

- **Clustering** — grouping similar data points (e.g., k-means, hierarchical clustering, DBSCAN).
- **Dimensionality reduction** — compressing data while preserving structure (e.g., PCA, t-SNE, UMAP, autoencoders).
- **Association rule learning** — finding relationships between variables (e.g., market-basket analysis).
- **Density estimation & anomaly detection** — modeling the underlying data distribution to flag outliers.

### 2.3 Semi-Supervised Learning

Combines a small amount of labeled data with a large amount of unlabeled data, useful when labeling is expensive.

### 2.4 Self-Supervised Learning

The model generates its own supervisory signal from unlabeled data — for example, predicting a masked word in a sentence or a missing patch in an image. This is the foundation of most modern large language models and many vision foundation models.

### 2.5 Reinforcement Learning (RL)

An agent learns to take actions in an environment to maximize cumulative reward through trial and error, rather than from a fixed dataset. Covered in depth in Section 12.

# 3. The Machine Learning Workflow

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## 1. Problem Definition

Clarify the business/scientific question, the target variable, and success criteria.

## 2. Data Collection

Gather relevant, representative data from databases, APIs, sensors, or web sources.

## 3. Data Cleaning & Preprocessing

Handle missing values, remove duplicates/outliers, normalize/scale features, encode categorical variables.

## 4. Exploratory Data Analysis (EDA)

Visualize distributions and relationships to understand the data before modeling.

## 5. Feature Engineering

Create, select, or transform variables to improve model performance (e.g., polynomial features, embeddings, binning).

## 6. Train/Validation/Test Split

Partition data so the model is evaluated on data it has not seen during training.

## 7. Model Selection & Training

Choose an algorithm/architecture and fit it to the training data.

## 8. Hyperparameter Tuning

Search over model settings (e.g., learning rate, tree depth) using validation performance, grid/random search, or Bayesian optimization.

## 9. Evaluation

Measure performance using appropriate metrics (Section 10) on held-out test data.

## 10. Deployment & Monitoring

Serve the model in production and continuously monitor for data drift or performance decay (Section 13).

## 4. Core Algorithms and Models

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### 4.1 Linear & Logistic Regression

**Linear regression** fits a straight-line (or hyperplane) relationship between features and a continuous target by minimizing squared error. **Logistic regression** extends this idea to classification by passing a linear combination of features through a sigmoid function to output a probability.

### 4.2 Decision Trees & Ensembles

- **Decision Trees** — split data recursively on feature thresholds to form a tree of decisions; easy to interpret but prone to overfitting.
- **Random Forests** — an ensemble of many decision trees trained on random subsets of data/features, combined by voting or averaging (bagging).
- **Gradient Boosting (e.g., XGBoost, LightGBM, CatBoost)** — builds trees sequentially, each correcting the errors of the previous ones; often state-of-the-art on tabular data.

### 4.3 Support Vector Machines (SVMs)

SVMs find the hyperplane that maximizes the margin between classes. With kernel functions (e.g., RBF, polynomial), SVMs can model non-linear decision boundaries by implicitly mapping data into higher-dimensional space.

### 4.4 k-Nearest Neighbors (k-NN)

A simple, non-parametric method that classifies or predicts a value based on the majority label or average of the k closest training examples in feature space.

### 4.5 Naive Bayes

A probabilistic classifier based on Bayes' theorem, assuming features are conditionally independent given the class. Fast, simple, and effective for tasks like text classification and spam filtering.

### 4.6 Clustering Algorithms

- **k-Means** — partitions data into k clusters by minimizing within-cluster variance.
- **Hierarchical Clustering** — builds a tree (dendrogram) of nested clusters.
- **DBSCAN** — groups points by density, naturally identifying outliers and arbitrary-shaped clusters.

### 4.7 Dimensionality Reduction

- **PCA (Principal Component Analysis)** — projects data onto orthogonal axes of maximum variance.
- **t-SNE / UMAP** — non-linear techniques primarily used for visualizing high-dimensional data in 2D/3D.

# 5. Neural Networks and Deep Learning

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## 5.1 The Artificial Neuron

A neuron computes a weighted sum of its inputs, adds a bias term, and passes the result through a non-linear **activation function**. Stacking neurons into layers, and layers into networks, allows the model to approximate complex functions (the "universal approximation" property).

## 5.2 Common Activation Functions

- **ReLU (Rectified Linear Unit)** —  $\max(0, x)$ ; simple, fast, the default choice for hidden layers.
- **Sigmoid** — squashes output to  $(0, 1)$ ; used for binary probabilities.
- **Tanh** — squashes output to  $(-1, 1)$ .
- **Softmax** — converts a vector of scores into a probability distribution over classes.
- **GELU / SiLU (Swish)** — smooth variants popular in modern Transformer architectures.

## 5.3 Forward Pass & Backpropagation

In the **forward pass**, input data flows through the network to produce a prediction. A **loss function** measures the error between prediction and ground truth. **Backpropagation** then computes the gradient of the loss with respect to every weight using the chain rule, and an optimizer (Section 9) updates the weights to reduce the loss. This process repeats over many iterations (epochs) until the model converges.

## 5.4 Layer Types

- **Fully Connected (Dense)** — every neuron connects to every neuron in the next layer.
- **Convolutional** — applies learned filters across spatial regions; ideal for images.
- **Recurrent** — processes sequences by maintaining a hidden state across time steps.
- **Attention / Self-Attention** — lets each element of a sequence weigh the relevance of every other element.
- **Normalization layers** (BatchNorm, LayerNorm) — stabilize and speed up training.
- **Dropout** — randomly disables neurons during training to reduce overfitting.

## 6. Deep Learning Architectures

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### 6.1 Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs)

CNNs use convolutional filters to detect local patterns (edges, textures, shapes) and pool them into increasingly abstract features. Landmark architectures include LeNet, AlexNet, VGG, ResNet (which introduced residual/skip connections to enable very deep networks), and EfficientNet.

### 6.2 Recurrent Neural Networks (RNNs), LSTM & GRU

RNNs process sequential data by passing information forward through time steps, but suffer from vanishing/exploding gradients on long sequences. **LSTM (Long Short-Term Memory)** and **GRU (Gated Recurrent Unit)** networks use gating mechanisms to preserve long-range dependencies, and were the standard for sequence modeling before Transformers.

### 6.3 The Transformer Architecture

Introduced in the 2017 paper "Attention Is All You Need," the Transformer replaced recurrence with **self-attention**, allowing all positions in a sequence to be processed in parallel while directly modeling relationships between any two tokens regardless of distance. Transformers are the backbone of virtually all modern large language and multimodal models.

- **Encoder-only** (e.g., BERT) — builds contextual representations, well-suited to understanding tasks.
- **Decoder-only** (e.g., GPT-family, Claude, Llama) — autoregressively predicts the next token; the dominant architecture for generative language models.
- **Encoder-decoder** (e.g., T5, original Transformer) — maps an input sequence to an output sequence, used in translation and summarization.

### 6.4 Generative Models

- **Autoencoders (AE) / Variational Autoencoders (VAE)** — learn compressed latent representations and can generate new data from that latent space.
- **Generative Adversarial Networks (GANs)** — a generator and discriminator are trained in competition, with the generator learning to produce increasingly realistic data.
- **Diffusion Models** — learn to reverse a gradual noising process, generating data (notably images, e.g., Stable Diffusion, DALL·E) by iteratively denoising random noise.

### 6.5 Graph Neural Networks (GNNs)

GNNs operate on graph-structured data (e.g., molecules, social networks) by propagating and aggregating information between connected nodes.



# 7. Natural Language Processing & Large Language Models

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## 7.1 Text Representation

- **Tokenization** — splitting text into words, subwords, or characters (e.g., Byte-Pair Encoding, WordPiece).
- **Word embeddings** — dense vector representations of words capturing semantic meaning (e.g., Word2Vec, GloVe).
- **Contextual embeddings** — representations that vary by context, produced by Transformer models.

## 7.2 Classic NLP Tasks

- Text classification & sentiment analysis
- Named entity recognition (NER)
- Part-of-speech tagging & parsing
- Machine translation
- Summarization (extractive and abstractive)
- Question answering

## 7.3 Large Language Models (LLMs)

LLMs are Transformer-based models pretrained on massive text corpora to predict the next token, then adapted for downstream use.

- **Pretraining** — self-supervised next-token prediction over large-scale text/code corpora, building broad linguistic and world knowledge.
- **Fine-tuning** — further training on a narrower, often labeled, dataset to specialize behavior.
- **Instruction tuning** — training on (instruction, response) pairs so the model follows natural-language commands.
- **RLHF / RLAI (Reinforcement Learning from Human or AI Feedback)** — aligning model outputs with human preferences by training a reward model and optimizing the policy against it.
- **Prompt engineering** — crafting inputs (instructions, examples, formatting) to elicit better outputs without changing model weights.
- **In-context learning** — the ability of LLMs to perform new tasks from examples given directly in the prompt, without weight updates.
- **Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG)** — combining a retrieval system (e.g., vector search over documents) with an LLM so responses are grounded in external, up-to-date information.
- **Fine-tuning methods** — full fine-tuning, and parameter-efficient methods such as LoRA (Low-Rank Adaptation) and adapters.
- **Agents** — LLMs that plan, call external tools/APIs, and take multi-step actions to accomplish goals.

## 7.4 Key Model Families (illustrative, non-exhaustive)

- GPT family (OpenAI), Claude family (Anthropic), Gemini (Google), Llama (Meta), Mistral, and others — decoder-only Transformers at various scales.
- BERT and its variants — encoder-only models widely used for classification and embedding tasks.

## 8. Computer Vision

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### 8.1 Core Tasks

- **Image classification** — assigning a label to an entire image.
- **Object detection** — locating and classifying multiple objects (e.g., YOLO, Faster R-CNN).
- **Semantic / instance segmentation** — labeling every pixel by class, or by individual object instance.
- **Pose estimation** — locating keypoints of objects/bodies.
- **Image generation & editing** — synthesizing or modifying images (GANs, diffusion models).
- **Optical character recognition (OCR)** — extracting text from images.

### 8.2 Vision Transformers (ViT)

Vision Transformers apply the Transformer architecture to images by splitting an image into patches, treating each patch as a token, and processing the sequence with self-attention — often matching or exceeding CNN performance at sufficient data/model scale.

### 8.3 Multimodal Models

Models such as CLIP align images and text in a shared embedding space, enabling zero-shot image classification and retrieval. Modern multimodal LLMs extend this further to accept and generate combinations of text, images, audio, and video.

# 9. Training Concepts & Optimization

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## 9.1 Loss Functions

- **Mean Squared Error (MSE)** — regression tasks.
- **Cross-Entropy Loss** — classification tasks.
- **Hinge Loss** — used by SVMs.
- **KL Divergence** — measures difference between probability distributions; used in VAEs and distillation.

## 9.2 Optimization Algorithms

- **Gradient Descent** — iteratively updates parameters in the direction that reduces loss.
- **Stochastic Gradient Descent (SGD)** — uses small random batches of data per update, adding noise that can help escape local minima.
- **Momentum** — accelerates SGD by accumulating a moving average of past gradients.
- **Adam / AdamW** — adaptive learning-rate optimizers that are the default for most deep learning today.

## 9.3 Key Hyperparameters

- **Learning rate** — step size of each parameter update; too high diverges, too low is slow to converge.
- **Batch size** — number of examples processed before each weight update.
- **Epochs** — number of full passes through the training dataset.
- **Learning rate schedule** — strategies (warmup, decay, cosine annealing) for varying the learning rate during training.

## 9.4 Transfer Learning

Reusing a model pretrained on a large, general dataset as the starting point for a new, related task, dramatically reducing the data and compute needed compared to training from scratch.

## 9.5 Scaling Laws

Empirical research shows model performance improves predictably as model size, dataset size, and compute increase together, following roughly power-law relationships — a key driver behind the trend toward larger foundation models.

# 10. Model Evaluation Metrics

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## 10.1 Classification Metrics

| Metric               | Definition                              | When to Use                              |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| Accuracy             | Correct predictions / total predictions | Balanced classes                         |
| Precision            | True positives / predicted positives    | Cost of false positives is high          |
| Recall (Sensitivity) | True positives / actual positives       | Cost of false negatives is high          |
| F1 Score             | Harmonic mean of precision and recall   | Imbalanced classes                       |
| ROC-AUC              | Area under the ROC curve (TPR vs. FPR)  | Ranking/threshold-independent evaluation |
| Confusion Matrix     | Table of predicted vs. actual classes   | Detailed error analysis                  |

## 10.2 Regression Metrics

- **MAE (Mean Absolute Error)** — average absolute difference between predictions and true values.
- **MSE / RMSE (Mean/Root Squared Error)** — penalizes larger errors more heavily.
- **R<sup>2</sup> (Coefficient of Determination)** — proportion of variance in the target explained by the model.

## 10.3 Ranking & Generative Metrics

- **NDCG, MAP, MRR** — used to evaluate ranked search/recommendation results.
- **BLEU, ROUGE, METEOR** — measure overlap between generated and reference text (translation/summarization).
- **Perplexity** — measures how well a language model predicts a sample; lower is better.
- **Human evaluation / LLM-as-judge** — increasingly used to assess open-ended generative outputs for helpfulness, correctness, and safety.

# 11. Overfitting, Regularization & Generalization

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**Overfitting** occurs when a model learns noise or overly specific patterns in the training data and fails to generalize to new data (low training error, high test error). **Underfitting** occurs when a model is too simple to capture the underlying pattern (high error on both training and test data). This trade-off is often described as the **bias-variance trade-off**.

## Common Regularization Techniques

- **L1 (Lasso) / L2 (Ridge) regularization** — penalize large weights to encourage simpler models.
- **Dropout** — randomly deactivates neurons during training.
- **Early stopping** — halts training once validation performance stops improving.
- **Data augmentation** — artificially expands training data (e.g., image rotations/crops) to improve robustness.
- **Cross-validation** — repeatedly splits data into folds to obtain a more reliable performance estimate and detect overfitting.
- **Batch/Layer normalization** — stabilizes training and can have a mild regularizing effect.

## 12. Reinforcement Learning

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In RL, an **agent** interacts with an **environment** over discrete time steps. At each step the agent observes a **state**, takes an **action** according to a **policy**, and receives a **reward** plus a new state. The goal is to learn a policy that maximizes expected cumulative (often discounted) reward.

### Key Concepts

- **Markov Decision Process (MDP)** — the mathematical framework underlying RL (states, actions, transition probabilities, rewards).
- **Value function** — expected return from a state (or state-action pair).
- **Exploration vs. exploitation** — balancing trying new actions against using known good ones.
- **Q-Learning / Deep Q-Networks (DQN)** — learn the value of taking an action in a state.
- **Policy Gradient methods (e.g., REINFORCE, PPO)** — directly optimize the policy function.
- **Actor-Critic methods** — combine a policy (actor) with a value estimator (critic) for more stable learning.
- **RLHF** — RL techniques applied to align LLMs with human preferences, central to modern chat-model training.

### Notable Milestones

- AlphaGo/AlphaZero (DeepMind) — mastered Go, chess, and shogi using deep RL combined with tree search.
- OpenAI Five / AlphaStar — competitive RL agents for complex video games (Dota 2, StarCraft II).
- RLHF-trained conversational assistants — applying human-feedback RL to align LLM behavior with helpfulness and safety goals.

## 13. MLOps & Deployment

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MLOps applies DevOps principles to machine learning, covering the full lifecycle from experimentation to production and ongoing maintenance.

- **Versioning** — tracking datasets, code, and model artifacts (e.g., DVC, MLflow, Git).
- **Experiment tracking** — logging hyperparameters, metrics, and results across runs.
- **CI/CD for ML** — automated testing and deployment pipelines for models.
- **Model serving** — exposing models via APIs, batch jobs, or edge deployment; considerations include latency, throughput, and cost.
- **Monitoring & drift detection** — tracking prediction quality over time and detecting when input data distributions shift (data drift) or model performance degrades (concept drift).
- **A/B testing & canary releases** — safely rolling out new model versions and comparing performance against the current production model.
- **Model compression** — quantization, pruning, and distillation to reduce model size/latency for deployment.



# 14. Ethics, Safety & Responsible AI

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## 14.1 Core Concerns

- **Bias & fairness** — models can inherit or amplify biases present in training data, leading to unfair outcomes across demographic groups.
- **Transparency & explainability** — many high-performing models (especially deep networks) are "black boxes"; techniques like SHAP, LIME, and attention visualization aim to make decisions more interpretable.
- **Privacy** — training data and deployed models can leak sensitive information; techniques like differential privacy and federated learning help mitigate this.
- **Robustness & security** — models can be vulnerable to adversarial examples, data poisoning, or prompt injection attacks.
- **Misinformation & misuse** — generative models can be used to create deceptive text, images, audio, or video (e.g., deepfakes).
- **Environmental impact** — training large models consumes significant energy and compute resources.
- **Job/economic impact** — automation of cognitive tasks raises questions about labor markets and the future of work.
- **Accountability & governance** — determining responsibility when AI systems cause harm, and establishing appropriate regulation.

## 14.2 AI Alignment & Safety Research

A growing research field focused on ensuring advanced AI systems reliably do what their designers and users intend, behave safely even in novel situations, and remain honest, harmless, and helpful as capabilities scale. Techniques include RLHF, red-teaming, interpretability research, constitutional/rule-based training methods, and evaluations for dangerous capabilities.

# 15. Real-World Applications

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## Healthcare

Medical image diagnosis, drug discovery, protein structure prediction (e.g., AlphaFold), patient risk prediction.

## Finance

Fraud detection, algorithmic trading, credit scoring, risk modeling.

## Retail & Marketing

Recommendation systems, demand forecasting, personalized advertising, customer segmentation.

## Autonomous Systems

Self-driving vehicles, drones, robotics perception and control.

## Manufacturing

Predictive maintenance, quality inspection via computer vision, supply chain optimization.

## Software Development

Code generation and completion, automated testing, bug detection.

## Science & Research

Climate modeling, materials discovery, astronomical data analysis, genomics.

## Everyday Tools

Virtual assistants, search engines, spam filters, translation, speech recognition, content moderation.

## 16. Glossary of Key Terms

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| Term                    | Definition                                                                                        |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Algorithm</b>        | A step-by-step procedure for solving a problem or performing a computation.                       |
| <b>Batch</b>            | A subset of training examples processed together before a parameter update.                       |
| <b>Bias (model)</b>     | Systematic error introduced by simplifying assumptions in a model.                                |
| <b>Embedding</b>        | A dense vector representation of data (words, images, etc.) capturing semantic properties.        |
| <b>Epoch</b>            | One complete pass through the entire training dataset.                                            |
| <b>Feature</b>          | An individual measurable input variable used by a model.                                          |
| <b>Fine-tuning</b>      | Further training a pretrained model on a smaller, task-specific dataset.                          |
| <b>Gradient Descent</b> | An optimization algorithm that adjusts parameters to minimize a loss function.                    |
| <b>Hyperparameter</b>   | A configuration value set before training (e.g., learning rate) rather than learned from data.    |
| <b>Inference</b>        | Using a trained model to make predictions on new data.                                            |
| <b>Label</b>            | The known correct output associated with a training example (supervised learning).                |
| <b>Latent Space</b>     | A compressed, learned representation space in which similar data points are close together.       |
| <b>Loss Function</b>    | A function measuring the difference between a model's predictions and the true values.            |
| <b>Overfitting</b>      | When a model fits training data too closely and fails to generalize to new data.                  |
| <b>Parameter</b>        | A value (e.g., weight, bias) learned by the model during training.                                |
| <b>Pretraining</b>      | Initial large-scale training of a model, often self-supervised, before task-specific fine-tuning. |
| <b>Token</b>            | A unit of text (word, subword, or character) used as input/output by an NLP model.                |
| <b>Weight</b>           | A learned parameter that scales the influence of an input on a neuron's output.                   |

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*This guide is a broad educational overview and is not exhaustive — AI/ML is a fast-moving field with new techniques emerging continually.*